

A DH Approach to the Literary and Forensic Style of Three Early French Translations of a Chinese Fiction Narrative

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Introduction

This project uses a corpus-based approach and NLP tools to explore concepts of style in translation.

We aim to isolate and describe key stylistic elements in a corpus of human translations of a single literary text. The source text (ST) is *Yu Jiao Li*, a “scholar-beauty romance” from the late Ming or early Qing dynasty (mid-seventeenth century). For various historical reasons, this text was translated into French three times during the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries. From French, one of these translations was subsequently rendered into several other European languages, including English, German, Dutch, and Danish. Widely read and discussed, this “Chinese novel” played a significant role in the emergence of the concept of “world literature” (Weltliteratur) among European intellectuals in the 1820s and 1830s (Youd, 2022).

The three French translations—i.e. target texts (TT)—are: T1) an unpublished partial translation of the narrative by Arcade Hoange (1679-1716) preserved in the Bibliothèque nationale de France; T2) Jean-Pierre Abel-Rémusat's (1788-1832) translation of the ST published in 1826; and T3) Stanislas Julien's (1797-1873) translation of the same text published in 1864.

Our analysis of these texts builds upon the foundations laid several decades ago by Mona Baker, who was one of the first to propose that researchers may be able to discern the “thumb-print” of a translator through the careful observation of linguistic features of translated texts (Baker, 2000, p. 245). Since that time many studies have taken up Baker's suggestion. Most relevant to our work is research that has focused on translated corpora based on Chinese language source texts. In particular, a number of insightful studies have analysed the multiple English translations of Cao Xueqin's *Honglou meng* (*The Dream of the Red Chamber*) (Li D., Zhang C., & Liu K. 2011; Liu, K., & Afzaal, M., 2021).

We are especially interested in measuring differences among the translated texts related to the following features: sentence length; type-token ratios; speech act report verbs and their modifications; and lexical bundles. Additionally, we seek to compare the TTs with the ST regarding these same features.

We will analyse our results with reference to the various factors of the translators' biographies (e.g. native–Abel-Rémusat and Julien–vs. non-native–Hoange–speakers of the target language) and their own expressly formulated approaches to translation (formulated by Abel-Rémusat and Julien in prefaces to their works).

Method

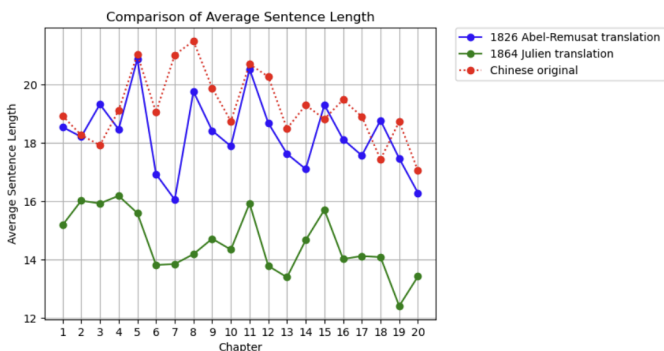
While our project is still in its early stages, we have begun by creating a high-quality corpus of our three French language translations of *Yu Jiao Li*. On the one hand, the printed, published texts of 1826 and 1864 have been relatively easy to process. On the other hand, we are still working to produce an accurate, computer readable file from the handwritten manuscript of the Hoange translation.

We are also in the process of constructing a number of comparison corpora: 1) a corpus of twenty to thirty original French language novels from the 1820s~1860s; and 2) a corpus of a similar number of French language translations of narrative fiction from the same period. In constructing the latter corpus, we are particularly interested in including works referenced by or likely to have been familiar to either Abel-Rémusat or Julien. This work is ongoing.

We have also been experimenting with different methods of tokenizing and tagging our texts.

Preliminary Observations: Sentence Length

Here we offer some very preliminary observations based on sentence length and POS (part of speech tagging). These data have been gathered using the off-the-shelf Python library spaCy, with the strong caveat that this is an imperfect tool for literary texts from previous centuries.



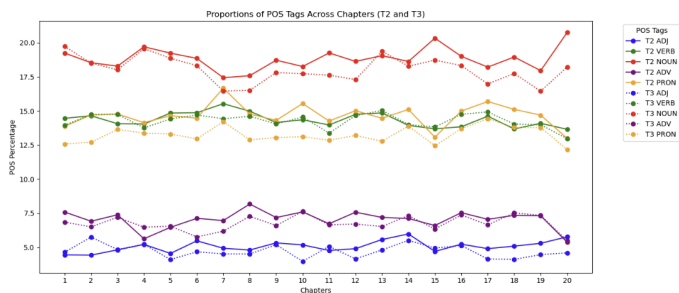
Based on the figure above, we observe a clear difference between the average sentence length of the two French translations, with sentences in the 1864 Julien translation consistently shorter across all twenty chapters of the novel. At the same time, with a few notable exceptions, the average sentence length in each translation rises and falls in a shared pattern. Note, also, that this pattern appears to follow in broad outline the fluctuation in sentence length across chapters in the Chinese source text.

Based on these data, it appears that Abel-Rémusat and Julien adopted different strategies when segmenting their same source text. Significantly, Julien claimed his retranslation of *Yu Jiao Li* was warranted because Abel-Rémusat's effort had been too "free." His shorter sentences may, therefore, correspond to a more academic and analytic style. This hypothesis deserves further investigation.

At this point, it is important to note that, because sentence boundaries are unmarked in the earliest surviving printed editions of the Chinese source text, we rely on modern editorial decisions for these indications. Moving forward, we will need to explore the definition of a sentence in the source text more fully. It is worth considering if the differences in average sentence length in the French translations may correspond to differences in how Abel-Rémusat and Julien parsed the source text.

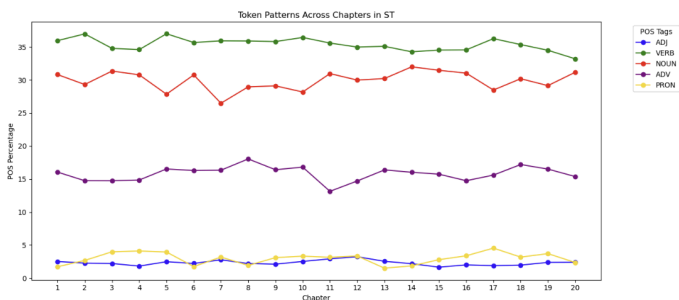
Preliminary Observations: Parts of Speech

At this stage of our research, we have also carried out a preliminary analysis of the parts of speech for both the Abel-Rémusat and Julien translations. The results are shown in the following table, where T2 refers to Abel-Rémusat's translation and T4 refers to Julien's:



Again, a general similarity between the two translations is immediately apparent with reference to all parts of speech. Nouns are the most frequently occurring part of speech across all chapters in both texts. Moreover, there is no discernible translator's style at this level of analysis.

In contrast, verbs predominate in the Chinese source text.



On the one hand, such results are expected, given the verb-centeredness of the Chinese language versus the noun-centeredness of French. On the other hand, this comparison lays the groundwork for further exploration of the translators' "thumb-print," as we search for stylistic idiosyncrasies in the ways the French translators handle nouns and noun phrases.

References

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